

Practice Paper 3: Answers and Marking Guide

Freedom and imprisonment; justice and mercy · Three hours · 100 marks

PAPER I · 40 MARKS

Answer **all** the questions in Section A. Select **either** I, II **or** III from Section B and answer all the questions given below it.

Paper I · Section A: Poetry, Prose and Drama 30 marks

Read the following extracts and answer all the questions given below them.

I POETRY

I (i) · PRACTICE QUESTION

"War is kind.
Hoarse, booming drums of the regiment
Little souls who thirst for fight,
These men were born to drill and die"

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|--|---------|
| (a) Name the poem from which these lines are taken. Name the poet. | 1 mark |
| (b) Who are the 'Little souls'? | 1 mark |
| (c) Name a sound device in the second line. | 1 mark |
| (d) What attitude to the soldiers is shown in these lines? | 2 marks |

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- (a) "War is Kind" by Stephen Crane.
- (b) The ordinary soldiers of the regiment.
- (c) Onomatopoeia ("booming") or alliteration ("Hoarse", "booming" / "drums"); either is acceptable.
- (d) Sympathy mixed with bitter irony. They are small and powerless ("Little souls"), trained only to march and die ("drill and die"). The first line is sarcastic: war is not kind at all.

I (ii) · PRACTICE QUESTION

"I don't want them to make
my little girl a princess.
In tiny golden slippers
how could she play on the meadow?"

- (a) Name the poem from which these lines are taken. Name the poet. 1 mark
- (b) Who is the speaker? 1 mark
- (c) What is the purpose of the question in the last line? 1 mark
- (d) What does the image of 'tiny golden slippers' suggest? 2 marks
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- (a) "Fear" by Gabriela Mistral (translated by Doris Dana).
- (b) A mother, speaking about her little girl.
- (c) It is a rhetorical question showing that luxury and status would stop the child enjoying simple, natural play.
- (d) Wealth and royal status, but also restriction: golden slippers are beautiful but not practical, so the child would lose her freedom and her closeness to her mother and to nature.

II PROSE

II (i) • PRACTICE QUESTION

"Your voice doesn't sound like aunt's," objected Nicholas; "you may be the Evil One tempting me to be disobedient."

- (a) Name the text from which these lines are taken. Name the author. 1 mark
- (b) To whom is Nicholas speaking? 1 mark
- (c) Where is the aunt at this moment? 1 mark
- (d) What features of Nicholas are revealed by these words? 2 marks
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- (a) "The Lumber Room" by Saki (H. H. Munro).
- (b) His aunt.
- (c) In the rain-water tank in the gooseberry garden, where she has slipped while searching for him.
- (d) He is clever, witty and cheeky. He uses the aunt's own words about "the Evil One" against her, and he takes revenge for her unfair punishments while pretending to be obedient.

II (ii) • PRACTICE QUESTION

"How can this man value his life less than mine? His sincerity was overwhelming. I felt humbled."

- (a) Name the text from which these lines are taken. Name the speaker/author. 1 mark
- (b) Who is 'this man'? 1 mark
- (c) What kind of question is the first sentence? 1 mark
- (d) What does this show about the speaker? 2 marks

- (a) "The Lahore Attack" by Kumar Sangakkara.
- (b) A Sri Lankan soldier, who told Sangakkara that it was all right if he died because that was his job, but that the cricketers were heroes whose loss would be great for the country.
- (c) A rhetorical question.
- (d) He is modest and grateful; he does not think his life is more valuable than another person's. He respects the man's courage and sincerity. Humility is a quality of a good leader.

III DRAMA

III (i) · PRACTICE QUESTION

"Yes, that's what the town-folk call it! They say cloth of that sort cannot be seen unless they go to the 'Tenjiku' (Heaven). It's as valuable as that."

- (a) Name the play from which these lines are taken. Name the playwright. 1 mark
- (b) Who is the speaker, and to whom? 1 mark
- (c) What are they talking about? 1 mark
- (d) Why is this conversation important for the plot? 2 marks

- (a) "Twilight of a Crane" by Junji Kinoshita.
- (b) Unzu, speaking to Sodo.
- (c) The senba-ori, the rare and precious "thousand-feather" cloth that Tsu weaves.
- (d) It shows how valuable the cloth is, so it awakens the greed of Sodo and Unzu. They decide to use Yohyo to get more cloth, which leads to Tsu's suffering and departure.

III (ii) · PRACTICE QUESTION

"You may have buried yourself alive, but you haven't forgotten to powder your face!"

- (a) Name the play from which these lines are taken. Name the playwright. 1 mark
- (b) Who speaks these words, and to whom? 1 mark
- (c) What does 'buried yourself alive' refer to? 1 mark

(d) What is the speaker suggesting? How does the listener react?

2 marks

(a) "The Bear" by Anton Chekhov.

(b) Smirnov, to Popova.

(c) Popova's vow to shut herself up in the house and mourn her husband for ever.

(d) He suggests that her mourning is a pretence and that she still cares about her looks and about men. She explodes with anger, which makes their quarrel worse and leads towards the duel.

Paper I · Section B: Novels 10 marks

Select **EITHER** I, II **OR** III and answer all the questions given below it.

I · THE PRINCE AND THE PAUPER

Read the following extract from *The Prince and the Pauper* by Mark Twain and answer all the questions given below it.

"I think the woman hath said true. An' my mother were in her place and gifted with the devil's functions, she had not stayed a moment to call her storms and lay the whole land in ruins, if the saving of my forfeit life were the price she got! It is argument that other mothers are made in like mould. Thou art free, goodwife—thou and thy child—for I do think thee innocent. Now thou'st nought to fear, being pardoned—pull off thy stockings!—an' thou canst make me a storm, thou shalt be rich!"

The redeemed creature was loud in her gratitude, and proceeded to obey, whilst Tom looked on with eager expectancy, a little marred by apprehension; the courtiers at the same time manifesting decided discomfort and uneasiness."

(i) When and where does this incident take place?

2 marks

(ii) Why does Tom decide that the woman is innocent?

2 marks

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) other mothers are made in like mould

1 mark

(b) a little marred by apprehension

1 mark

(iv) What does this incident reveal about Tom? Why is it also humorous?

4 marks

(i) When and where does this incident take place?

In the palace, when Tom, acting as King, sits in judgement on prisoners; a woman and her little daughter are accused of witchcraft (raising a storm by pulling off their stockings).

(ii) Why does Tom decide that the woman is innocent?

He reasons that if she really had such power, she would have used it to save her child's life, as his own mother would have done. Since she did not, she cannot be a witch.

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) other mothers are made in like mould

All mothers are alike (they would do anything to save their children).

(b) a little marred by apprehension

Slightly spoilt by worry or fear.

(iv) What does this incident reveal about Tom? Why is it also humorous?

It shows Tom's kindness, common sense and sense of justice: he is wiser and more merciful than the cruel law, and the court begins to respect him. It is humorous because he is curious and childlike, asking her to make a storm, while the courtiers feel uncomfortable. Theme: justice and mercy matter more than birth; the cruelty of the laws of the time.

II • BRINGING TONY HOME

The narrator has returned to his old neighbourhood. In the middle of a gathering at Mrs. Jayasingha's, he hears a familiar sound:

"And then came the bark; the sharp clipped aristocratic bark, and with it came Tony"

(i) What is the situation, and where does it take place? 2 marks

(ii) Why is Tony so excited? 2 marks

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) sharp clipped 1 mark

(b) aristocratic 1 mark

(iv) Comment on the narrator's description of Tony's bark. What does it reveal about their relationship?
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(i) What is the situation, and where does it take place?

The joyful reunion of the narrator with his dog Tony, when he comes back to Depanama after the family has moved; it takes place at Mrs. Jayasingha's.

(ii) Why is Tony so excited?

He has been separated from the boy he loves, and he suddenly recognises him again.

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) sharp clipped

Short, quick and clear.

(b) aristocratic

Proud and dignified, as if it belonged to a noble.

(iv) Comment on the narrator's description of Tony's bark. What does it reveal about their relationship?

The narrator describes the bark with affection and humour, as if Tony were a proud nobleman. He recognises it instantly, which shows how well he knows the dog. The reunion shows loyalty and love on both sides, and prepares for the boy's determination to bring Tony home. Themes: the human-animal bond; parting and reunion.

III · THE VENDOR OF SWEETS

Mali has just arrived home from America with a young woman. A crowd and a photographer are present. Jagan is confused, but holds back his questions because:

"Any indiscreet question might upset the gentlemen with the camera."

- (i) When and where does this happen? 2 marks
- (ii) What has confused Jagan? 2 marks
- (iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) indiscreet question 1 mark
(b) upset the gentlemen with the camera 1 mark
- (iv) What does this incident reveal about Jagan and about the change in Mali? 4 marks

(i) When and where does this happen?

When Mali returns from America, at the moment of his arrival in Malgudi, before they drive home in Gaffur's taxi.

(ii) What has confused Jagan?

Mali introduces the girl as Grace and says they are married. Jagan did not know about any marriage and does not know who she is.

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) indiscreet question

A tactless or embarrassing question.

(b) upset the gentlemen with the camera

Cause trouble or a scene in front of the photographer/press.

(iv) What does this incident reveal about Jagan and about the change in Mali?

Jagan is shocked but cares about appearances and avoids a scene; he is timid with his son. Mali has changed: he marries without telling his father, ignoring Indian custom, and speaks in a new American style. Themes: generation gap; East and West; tradition and modernity.

Paper II · Essays 60 marks

PAPER II · 60 MARKS

Answer **four** questions, selecting **one** each from the four sections: Poetry, Drama, Prose and Fiction.

HOW PAPER II ESSAYS ARE MARKED (15 MARKS EACH)

Content 7 · Organisation 4 · Language 4. Examiners reward relevant points from the text, apt quotations, a clear argument that answers the question, and your own sensible response. The points below are a guide, not a fixed list.

POETRY (Answer one question only)

1. How does Emily Dickinson use unusual images to describe the bird in 'A Bird Came Down the Walk'?

15 marks

- Introduction: an ordinary event (a bird eating a worm) becomes poetry.
- Realistic and surprising: "He bit an Angle Worm in halves / And ate the fellow, raw".
- Humanised behaviour: he "drank a Dew / From a convenient Grass" and "hopped sidewise to the Wall / To let a Beetle pass".
- Fear: "They looked like frightened Beads"; "He stirred his Velvet Head".
- Flight as rowing: "rowed him softer Home - / Than Oars divide the Ocean, / Too silver for a seam".
- Butterflies "Leap, plashless as they swim": movement through air described as water.
- Techniques: personification, simile, metaphor, dashes, capitals.
- Conclusion: unusual images reveal the beauty, delicacy and mystery of nature.

2. "In 'Breakfast', Prévert tells a whole story through simple actions." Discuss.

15 marks

- Introduction: the poem (translated by Reggie Siriwardena) describes a man and a woman at breakfast, seen through the woman's eyes.
- The man's actions: pouring coffee, adding milk and sugar, smoking, putting on his hat and raincoat, leaving in the rain.
- What is missing: he does it all "without talking" and "without looking" at her.
- The woman's reaction at the end: she weeps.
- Form: short lines, repetition, no direct emotional words until the end.
- Suggestion: a broken relationship and loneliness; the reader infers the story.

- Conclusion: simple language and repetition create powerful feeling.

3. Examine how Maya Angelou uses contrast in 'I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings'.

15 marks

- Introduction: a poem about freedom and oppression.
- The free bird: "leaps on the back / Of the wind"; "dares to claim the sky"; "names the sky his own".
- The caged bird: "can seldom see through his bars of rage"; "His wings are clipped and his feet are tied".
- Why he sings: "So he opens his throat to sing"; "of things unknown / But longed for still".
- Dark imagery: "stands on the grave of dreams"; "His shadow shouts on a nightmare scream".
- Structure: alternating stanzas, repeated refrain "the caged bird sings of freedom".
- Wider meaning: the struggle of oppressed people, especially African Americans.
- Conclusion: contrast gives the poem its power and hope.

4. "'The Earthen Goblet' is a lament for lost freedom and natural beauty." Discuss.

15 marks

- Introduction: the poet asks a goblet about its past; the goblet replies.
- Its former life in the earth: "My bosom buried deep".
- Friendship with nature: "Fragrant friendship"; "With just one flower flaming through my breast".
- Resistance to change: "I felt a conscious impulse in my clay, to break away".
- The potter: creator, but also a controlling force; art versus nature.
- Wider meaning: loss of innocence, freedom or rural life under modern pressures.
- Conclusion: the poem invites sympathy for what is lost when something is reshaped.

5. How does Edward Lowbury use repetition and a twist ending in 'The Huntsman'?

15 marks

- Introduction: a narrative poem based on a folk tale.
- The repeated question "How did you come here?" and answer "Talking brought me here".
- The skull's silence in front of the guards: "The skull said nothing."
- Kagwa's death: "They killed him with sword and spear."
- The twist: the skull asks Kagwa the same question and he answers with the same words.

- Irony: talking brings Kagwa to the same fate as the skull.
- Theme: the danger of careless talk and of boasting.
- Conclusion: repetition makes the moral clear and the ending memorable.

DRAMA (Answer one question only)

6. Discuss the importance of the cloth (senba-ori) in 'Twilight of a Crane'.

15 marks

- Introduction: Tsu weaves a rare cloth from her own feathers.
- A symbol of love: she weaves it for Yohyo at great cost.
- Value and greed: the town-folk say it is as valuable as heaven; Sodo and Unzu see profit.
- A test of trust: Yohyo must not watch her weave.
- Physical sacrifice: each cloth weakens Tsu.
- The ending: two pieces are left as she departs.
- Conclusion: the cloth links the themes of love, sacrifice and greed.

7. "Popova changes more than Smirnov in 'The Bear'." Do you agree?

15 marks

- Introduction: both characters change completely in a short time.
- Popova: from a mourning widow who refuses to leave the house to a woman who accepts Smirnov's love.
- Her vow: "I shall never go out" and her love for her husband's memory.
- Smirnov: from a woman-hater ("I'd rather sit on a barrel of gunpowder than talk to a woman") to a lover who proposes.
- Who changes more? Arguments for each.
- Both are proud and stubborn; the duel brings out their real feelings.
- Conclusion: a clear personal view with examples.

PROSE (Answer one question only)

8. How does the writer use language to convey confusion and terror in the extract from 'Wave'?

15 marks

- Introduction: a first-person memoir.
- Harmless first impressions: "white curl of a big wave".
- Direct speech: "Oh my God, the sea's coming in."

- Short sentences and silence: "No one spoke. No one uttered a sound."
- Confusion: she flees without understanding.
- Detailed physical sensations make the scene vivid.
- Conclusion: plain, precise language makes the horror real.

9. What does the lumber-room represent in 'The Lumber Room'?

15 marks

- Introduction: a locked, forbidden room in the aunt's house.
- Mystery: "that region that was so carefully sealed from youthful eyes".
- Imagination: the tapestry, the candlesticks, the china-duck teapot, the book of birds.
- Contrast: "Such parts of the house as Nicholas knew best were rather bare and cheerless".
- Adult attitudes: the aunt thinks "things spoil by use".
- Freedom: "Nicholas was in an unknown land".
- Conclusion: the room stands for the world of imagination that strict adults lock away.

10. "'We are Sri Lankan.' How does 'The Lahore Attack' express national pride and unity?"

15 marks

- Introduction: the attack and the speaker's purpose.
- Unity under attack: players protect one another.
- Pride: "we were not cowed. We were not down and out."
- Calm: "absolute clarity and awareness".
- Responsibility as "unofficial ambassadors".
- Respect for others: humility before those who protected them.
- Conclusion: the speech shows sport as a source of national pride.

11. "The ending of 'The Nightingale and the Rose' is bitterly ironic." Discuss.

15 marks

- Introduction: the Nightingale dies to create the red rose.
- The Student calls it luck: "Why, what a wonderful piece of luck!"
- The girl rejects it: "I am afraid it will not go with my dress"; jewels "cost far more than flowers".
- The rose is thrown away: it falls into the gutter and "a cart-wheel went over it".
- The Student's final view of love and his return to books.
- Irony: the greatest sacrifice is wasted and unnoticed.

- Conclusion: Wilde criticises a materialistic, practical society.

FICTION (Answer one question only)

12. "Edward's sufferings among the poor teach him to be a better king." Discuss.

15 marks

- Introduction: the prince loses his place and lives as a pauper.
- Harsh treatment: mocked, beaten by John Canty, threatened by tramps.
- He sees injustice: cruel punishments, poverty, unfair laws.
- Help and kindness from Miles Hendon and some ordinary people.
- Humility, for example the scene with the rat in the barn.
- As king he shows mercy and rewards those who helped him.
- Conclusion: experience, not birth, makes him wise.

13. Discuss the narrator's courage and determination in 'Bringing Tony Home'.

15 marks

- Introduction: a boy who cannot accept losing his dog.
- His secret vow to bring Tony home.
- He uses the errands (ration books, the mirror) as a chance to return to Depanama.
- The reunion and his decision to walk the long way home with Tony.
- His care for Tony on the journey.
- His sorrow and maturity when Tony leaves.
- Conclusion: determination and love drive the story.

14. "Jagan's Gandhian ideals are more convenient than sincere." Do you agree?

15 marks

- Introduction: Jagan's admiration for Gandhi.
- Sincere practices: khadi, spinning, simple food, non-violence.
- Convenient practices: untaxed money, using Gandhian ideas to avoid giving money to Mali.
- Non-violent non-cooperation in the family quarrel.
- His retreat across the river.
- Conclusion: a balanced answer with examples.

These are original LitHelp practice questions written to the format of the G.C.E. (O/L) 2023(2024) and 2024(2025) papers and the Ministry of Education's 2025(2026) model papers. They are not official past-paper questions. For copyrighted set texts, only short lines are quoted and the situation is described in our own words.